

Requirements Document for US-Based Rental Property Management

Project: Hybrid HOA & Rental Property Management Platform

Reference Model: Avail and TenantCloud Features

Compliance: USA Landlord-Tenant Law & US IRS tax codes

Section 1: Database Architecture and Role Re-alignment

1. User roles will be extended to include: Landlord, Tenant, and Service Professional (Vendor).
2. Establish hierarchical database tables: properties (containing address, details, and owner_id), units (representing distinct apartments or rooms linked to a property), and leases (binding a landlord, tenant, and unit).
3. Link all financial transactions and ledgers directly to the lease record rather than the community level.

Section 2: Onboarding Flow

1. Landlords must be able to sign up directly via self-service registration (without requiring a sales onboarding contract code).
2. Post sign-up, the landlord can add properties, define units, and invite tenants by inputting their email address.
3. Invited tenants will receive an email link, register their account, verify their email/phone, and automatically link to their assigned unit and lease.

Section 3: Tenant Screening & Rental Applications

1. Prospective tenants must be able to submit online rental applications containing employment details, income declarations, references, and pet/occupant details.
2. Integrate a background check API (such as TransUnion SmartMove or RentPrep) to pull credit scores, national eviction history, and criminal record reports.
3. Render screening reports directly on the landlord dashboard in a clean, print-friendly text format.

Section 4: Lease Agreement & E-Signatures

1. Landlord can configure lease details: start date, end date, rent amount, security deposit amount, grace period, and late fee terms.
2. System will generate a text lease agreement customized by state.
3. Landlord and Tenant can sign the agreement digitally using integrated text-based e-signature fields. The signed document is stored as a read-only PDF.

Section 5: Rent Payments & Ledgers (USA Banking Rules)

1. System will automatically generate an invoice for rent on the 1st of every month.

2. Integrate ACH (Direct Bank Transfer via Plaid/Stripe) to enable low-fee rent payments for tenants, which is the standard payment method in the US.
3. Allow late fees (e.g. flat \$50 or 5% of monthly rent) to be automatically added to the due balance if payment is not received by the end of the grace period (usually the 5th of the month).
4. Track the tenant security deposit in a separate ledger, designated for escrow holdings.

Section 6: Maintenance Desk & Vendor Dispatch

1. Tenants can raise maintenance tickets (e.g. broken AC, plumbing issues) and attach photo/video logs.
2. Landlord can assign tickets to Service Professionals (Vendors) and track status (Open, Closed, In-Progress, Vendor Assigned).
3. Log all paid maintenance bills as property expenses in the financial module.

Section 7: Financial Accounting & US Tax Forms (1099)

1. Maintain a master ledger of all income (rent, fees) and expenses (repairs, utilities) per property.
2. Automatically track total payments to each vendor/service professional.
3. Generate IRS Form 1099-MISC/1099-NEC at the end of the tax year for any vendor paid over \$600.

Section 8: Workspace Selection (HOA vs Rental Mode)

1. Account owners can choose the system behavior: HOA/Condo Association Mode or Rental Property Mode.
2. Based on this choice, the system dynamically filters dashboard tabs. In Rental Mode, tabs like e-Voting, Surveys, and Board Meetings are hidden. In HOA Mode, tabs like Tenant Screening and Leases are hidden.

Section 9: WHAT WE WILL ADD TO THE APPLICATION

1. **Self-Service Landlord Registration Flow:** Landlords can register accounts independently without requiring corporate sales onboarding codes.
2. **Tenant Screening & Applications Page:** Forms to collect tenant background information and display credit, criminal, and eviction screening reports.
3. **Lease & E-Signature Hub:** Lease generator tool customized by US states, complete with e-signature sign boxes and static contract generation.
4. **Stripe/Plaid ACH Payments Integration:** USA standard low-fee automated bank-to-bank direct debit system for rent payments.
5. **Automated Late Fees & Billing Engine:** Logic to automatically add penalties to ledgers after the 5th day grace period.
6. **Maintenance Vendor Marketplace & Dispatch:** Dashboard to assign repair tickets to independent service professionals.
7. **IRS Form 1099 Tax Module:** Auto-tracking of vendor payouts and generation of 1099-MISC tax documents.

8. **Property & Unit Management Hub:** Screens for landlords to create properties (buildings) and add distinct rentable units.

Section 10: WHAT WE WILL REMOVE / HIDE FROM THE APPLICATION

1. **e-Voting & Balloting (eVoting):** Removed/hidden in Rental Mode. Private rental properties do not hold public democratic board votes.
2. **Surveys & Neighborhood Polls:** Removed/hidden in Rental Mode. Tenant relations are lease-based rather than community-consensus based.
3. **HOA Board Meetings & Minutes Hub:** Hidden in Rental Mode. Public board hearings, RSVP listings, and meeting summary transcriptions are disabled.
4. **HOA Violations & Fine Dispute Board:** Replaced in Rental Mode. Neighbor code violations (e.g. grass height, paint colors) do not apply to rental tenants. Lease infraction notices are handled privately instead of via public board dispute boards.
5. **Public Neighborhood Announcements Board:** Hidden in Rental Mode. Announcements are replaced by private direct messages/notices from landlord to tenants.
6. **Public Document Archives (CC&Rs, Bylaws):** Hidden in Rental Mode. Community rules archives are replaced with private lease agreement documents.
7. **Multi-Community Carousel Hub:** Removed for Landlords. Replace the 'All Communities' overview carousel with a private property portfolio dashboard.